NARI SHAKTI ACT

on caste politics. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav put the demand forcefully: no women's reservation without OBC representation within it. If OBCs turn out to be more than half the population, a plausible outcome, proportional reservation will become a political migraine the BJP will find impossible to finesse: upper-caste pushback on one side, an OBC vote bank the party cannot afford to alienate on the other. Fast-tracking delimitation before the OBC numbers are out would have closed the window, at least for a generation, on the most explosive demand.

But the difficulty in implementation is even more acute. There is no current constitutional framework for OBC reservation in the Lok Sabha. The last full caste count widely relied upon for backward class estimates is from 1931. The Mandal Commission, working from older data and extrapolations, estimated OBCs to be around 52 per cent of the population. The 2011 Socio-Economic and Caste Census did collect caste information, but those caste-wise figures were never fully published in a manner that produced a settled national denominator for representation. This is why the Opposition and social justice parties are eagerly awaiting the outcome of the 2027 Census, for it would be the first time in almost 100 years that they would get material evidence.

Experts say that if the familiar 27 per cent OBC formula used in public employment is applied in Parliament, the figure would be about 147 seats in the current House. Since 131 seats are already reserved for SCs/ STs, it would mean half the seats in Parliament would fall in the reserved category. The moment one accepts the principle of OBC reservation in Parliament, the next demand becomes inevitable: one-third of those OBC-reserved seats must also go to OBC women. That would create a layered reservation matrix—general women, SC women, ST women, OBC women—requiring an entirely new constitutional architecture. What appears to be a simple one-third women's quota will thus become a highly complex redistribution mechanism across both gender and caste lines.

Q. IS THE SOUTHERN FORMULA OF GDP GROWTH FOR SEAT SHARE VIABLE?

Telangana chief minister A. Revanth Reddy has proposed a 50-50 hybrid model: half of any new Lok Sabha seats allocated by population, half by contribution to gross domestic product. K.T. Rama Rao of the Bharat Rashtra Samithi has advanced a harder variant—delimit on "fiscal contributions to the nation". Kerala Congress (M) leader Jose K. Mani has argued for a broader, more calibrated version of the same idea: a multi-factor matrix that blends demographic weight with success at population control, economic contribution, human development outcomes and social progress. Mani's formula is, in effect, a translation into political vocabulary of the Finance Commission's devolution criteria and is thus a sophisticated import into the delimitation debate. The 16th Finance Commission, whose report under Arvind Panagariya was submitted to the President on November 17, 2025, and awaits tabling in Parliament, has raised the demographic-performance weight and introduced a GDP-contribution criterion in the revenue devolution formula (*see graphic*: Can delimitation use the revenue sharing formula?).

Yet that argument may not hold much water, for in GDP terms, the gap between the North and South is narrowing. The five biggest north Indian states account for 29 per cent of India's GDP. The five biggest south Indian states contribute 31 per cent. Shastri is sceptical of layering delimitation with economic variables like GDP, which he believes can be politicised in ways that may destabilise rather than help



RIDE TO RESERVATION Women at a scooter rally organised by the BJP, Lucknow, Apr. 15

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"WOMEN'S RESERVATION SHOULD TAKE PLACE RIGHT AWAY. DELIMITATION REQUIRES TIME AND DISCUSSION WITH STAKEHOLDERS. DO NOT LINK THE TWO AND RAM IT DOWN. THAT IS WHAT AROUSES SUSPICION"

K.M. CHANDRASEKHAR, *Former cabinet secretary*